Blanquerna–Ramon Llull University, School of Communication and International Relations, Official Master's degree in Advanced Studies in International Affairs

Subject: Introduction to the Theory of International Relations (141148-Supplementary course) – 2025-26

Title of the essay : Climate changes explained, through the lens of the three traditions of International Thought : Realism, Rationalism and Revolutionism.

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Word-count : 1030 words.

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Throughout the recent years, climate change has been one the most challenging themes that I.R. Climate disasters are multiplying, international summits are taking place, in order to tackle this crucial subject, which is widely considered as the most crucial challenge that International Relations, as a discipline, has to face. (*IPCC, 2023*). However, international response to this challenge has not always been coordinated. The discipline of I.R, tends to question and answer the question "why". For this, Human nature creates realms, and different explanations, to understand reality, that is always complex. This essay will try to understand the explanation of this phenomena, in the prism of different schools of thought, in international relations, just as Martin Wright presented, as the Schools of Thought. *(Wight, 1991*) We will see, first, the Rationalist view, a theoretical approach, that emphasises the role of reason, among actors, in this international system, it will be answered by States, within a system that is considered to be anarchical.*(Baylis, Smith and Owens, 2023*) For them, balance is key. Then, we will see the view of the realist paradigm, that sees climate change as a topic of Strategic and Political Field, power and competition. For them interest goes first and cooperation then. Finally, we will see, the Revolutionist view, that will overcome the traditionalist explanation, and see the climate change, in a more broad explanation of I.R , ot as a problem of coordination between states (as the rationalist would say), but as a moral and structural crisis of the international system itself.

First of all, so, as announced, the Rationalist view. For them, science is very important, and climate change is part of it. It's a consequence of human behaviour, and it can be proved scientifically. It's key to understand this theory, for example, the scientific work of the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change. According to this theory, this expert panel would be useful to explain climate change, because they provide rigorous scientific works that establish a clear causal relationship between human activity and global warming, but most globally Climate Change. We see, then, a very important pattern of reason. We as humans fail to act 'rationally' and do what it's best for us. The problem is not structural or ideological but epistemic and ethical: people know what must be done but fail to act rationally. We know that climate change is key to protecting the planet, but we fail to act. The solution would be, to act for our best interest, strengthening cooperation within actors, strengthening education, and raising awareness on the importance of this subject, creating a global community, to create decisions that would be the "best for all", regardless of interest, and based on reason. However, there are some limits that would weaken this realm of international relations. First of all, how can we explain the fact that there exists, political denial of Climate change, Populism, if all individuals act rational, and there is a consensus on the importance of climate change ? If we follow only the Rationalist view, climate change scepticism is impossible. The Realist perspective, based in the lectures of Thomas Hobbes, or Niccolo Machiavelli's would explain I.System as an anarchical and pessimistic view of I.R, and this would be no stranger, regarding Climate Change. *(Hobbes, 1651; Machiavelli, 1532)*. It's the famous "*Tragedy of the commons*"*(Hardin, 1968*) in which no one is capable of restraining himself to exploit the resources. The international system will be based in Perpetual conflict, Balance of power and the weakening of moral ideals. States would search for their own survival, which is an important value in this topic. Therefore, Climate Change

would be dealt with in an extremely political, and a pragmatic way. Climate policies would be only a tool, shaped by power politics, and no alliance would be a long lasting one. But how would a realist explain this theory ?

In the Realist realm, we know that States cooperate only when it serves their own interests. Climate change could be, then, a consequence of industrial competition, geopolitical rivalry, and economic growth. Climate change would challenge the Balance of Power, and intensify Geopolitical Conflicts. This realm, would put in a second plan, all the bilateral and multilateral cooperation, that Climate Change would be a consequence of, and exist only through the prism of States. It would be an explanation of perpetual war, and maybe also, a consequence of the "war" on resources, that powers tend to accumulate, and therefore challenge the equilibrium. There will be no Social dimensions of Climate Change. For me, realist, would not propose any "solution" on climate change, because it would be inherent to the system. Because the system is Anarchical, the asymmetrical powers tend to exploit resources, and it would be the battle for the "gold medal". Regional and bilateral agreements on climate change would therefore constrain.

The last, but not the least prism of reality, that would try to tackle Climate Change, would be Revolutionism. For them, Climate Change would not be seen as a shared global problem requiring cooperation, but as a consequence of the inherent, destructive logic of capitalism, which prioritizes profit over people and the planet. It's a theory that is considered Revolutionism, because it would challenge the system and challenge the Status-Quo. For me it would probably be the most "radical" one, in the sense that it tackles climate change, as a more broad and wide question: Capitalism and the failure of action. The never-ending quest for profit in capitalism is what causes climate change. Inter-state cooperation would be inefficient because of national economic interests and competition, that would deviate the "fight", from the original purpose. Climate Change does not impact everyone, and therefore it's considered as a class issue. What is the solution then ? There is only one solution, following this realm, that would be to overthrow the system and create a new society. Solution would need to be radical and maybe, what changes the most, respect of the others theory would be the 'systematic' approach, and the more radical one.

Finally, this theme of the essay, theory of international relations, permits us to understand the international system, and politics, through different prisms and realities.

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